

Reversing the Influence: *Deadpool* & *Wolverine* as User-Generated Content

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In today's media environment, where audience engagement is reshaping how stories are told, *Deadpool & Wolverine* stands out as a prime example of fan-driven creativity in filmmaking. This film is a love letter to Marvel's dedicated fanbase and shows how user-generated content revolutionizes storytelling and marketing. By blending nostalgia, interactive marketing strategies, and self-aware humour, it illustrates the powerful influence of fandom in shaping popular culture, therefore redefining the relationship between Hollywood and its audiences as we are now" in a world in which the line between consumers and producers is blurring" (Jenkins et al. (2009)...). From the film's opening sequence—featuring Nsync's hit song "Bye Bye Bye"—to surprise cameos from beloved Marvel characters like Blade, Electra, and Laura (X-23), this film's content is as rich as its fandom (White, 2024).

This paper analyzes Marvel's use of a bottom-up, fan-driven approach in creating and marketing *Deadpool & Wolverine*, demonstrating how fan-generated enthusiasm, interactivity, and social media participation have created a cultural phenomenon, however short-lived it may be. Marvel has renewed interest in its cinematic universe by engaging audiences as active participants in the narrative process. Especially since they have had 'several high-profile disappointments lately ' (Bahr, 2024), such as *Ant-Man and the Wasp: Quantumania* (2023) and *The Marvels* (2023). The success of *Deadpool & Wolverine* stands out in this context, as it redefined the dynamics between creator and consumer.

Deadpool (Wade Wilson), played by Ryan Reynolds, and Wolverine (Logan), played by Hugh Jackman, invite their audience to engage with the film through nostalgia, laughter, and many heartfelt moments. In the context of this film, 'user-generated content' refers to the plotline being made from opinions from fans rather than being decided by the studio. This film demonstrates how public opinion, fandom-generated content and participatory culture are changing the modern media scene. This is especially seen in the Marvel Universe, which has

cultivated one of pop culture's most devoted fan bases. This fandom is not only known for consuming the brand's vast array of comics, films, and television shows but also for actively engaging with the source material.

Deadpool and Wolverine are two of the most unconventional pair-ups in the Marvel Universe, with their dynamic being rooted in previous comics (Dockterman, 2024). Wolverine's stoic demeanour strongly contrasts Deadpool's chaotic, foul-mouthed shenanigans. Their complicated relationship is based on a balance in their 'frenemyship,' bringing audiences in with their verbal sparring, unconventional methods of achieving shared goals, and, in the end, mutual respect for one another. This film gave fans the collaboration they craved ever since Reynolds first portrayed Wade Wilson in *X-Men Origins: Wolverine* (2009). That portrayal is criticized for its creative liberties, mainly sewing Wade's mouth shut. Reynolds' reprisal in *Deadpool* (2016) is seen as an apology to fans, as he finally gives them a fully chaotic and comedic character. Even though *X-Men Origins: Wolverine* disappointed most, it did play a role in igniting Ryan Reynolds' determination to give the character a proper on-screen revival. Reynolds' portrayal incorporated everything that makes Deadpool unique, from his irreverence to his self-awareness to his endless inappropriate quips. Additionally, his push for a true-to-comics, R-rated version of Deadpool was vital to bringing the first, let alone the third, to fruition.

Historically, film marketing relied solely on traditional advertising methods, such as trailers, posters and promotional appearances. However, the internet and social media rise has urged a clear shift towards a fandom-driven approach to marketing goods. At its core, Deadpool, as a character, embodies the participatory culture of modern media. Participatory culture, in *Confronting the Challenges of Participatory Culture: Media Education for the 21st Century* (2009), refers to the shift in media production and consumption where fans actively participate in creating, critiquing, and circulating media content (Jenkins et al., pp. xi-xii). Audiences are not passive recipients anymore. They are pushed to engage with multiple forms

of media in ways that influence its development. This shift is rooted in "epistemophilia - not simply a pleasure in knowing but a pleasure in exchanging knowledge" (Baym, 1998), which has become a mainstay in modern fandoms (Kassing, 2015, p. 13). Deadpool's success can be attributed mainly to this culture, where fan feedback, online interaction, and digital content creation are integral to the franchise's growth. Marvel is clever in harnessing the enthusiasm of its audience to create its very own participatory culture, amplified by social media platforms like TikTok, Instagram, and Reddit. These fan communities share their opinions, fan art, theories, and memes, which create free paratexts for both the films and characters, adding to the hype (Bi, 2019; Geraets, 2024; Guo, 2022, p. 225; Leno, 2024). Ryan Reynolds' portrayal of Deadpool taps into this fan culture by breaking the fourth wall as the character is known to do, making jokes about real-world events, and referencing internet culture—all of which invite audiences to feel like they are part of the action. Deadpool mirrors the audience: he is self-aware, irreverent, and always in on the joke, no matter how bad the joke may be.

Joke Hermes notes that "popular culture studies will mostly turn into audience studies" (p. 37), showing the importance of examining audiences' role in shaping cultural products. The film's marketing strategy was mainly about promoting a product and building a community around the characters and narratives that fans love (*Beyond traditional ads*, 2024; Chilton, 2024a; McClintock, 2024; Leno, 2024). Ryan Reynolds blurs the line between creator and fan via his social media accounts, sometimes in character as Deadpool. The same can be said for Hugh Jackman, who participated in similar fan interactions and even surprise appearances at comic conventions. Some examples of their marketing are the viral "Ryan Reynolds vs. Hugh Jackman" videos, in which the two actors compete against each other. Their playful banter was a hit with viewers and showed off their genuine friendship, creating even more excitement. The marketing campaign was loaded with self-aware content that felt just like Deadpool, making it easy for the audience to connect on a personal level (*Beyond traditional ads*, 2024; Chilton, 2024a; McClintock, 2024). Thanks to Ryan Reynolds' advertising firm, Maximum Effort, the

marketing focused on connecting with fans directly based on their wants and needs. The trailers did not spoil any major plot points of cameos and had just enough chaos and humour to spark curiosity, which sparked fans' buzzing with theories and excitement. Fans eagerly speculate about the plot and who might show up.

However, Maximum Effort continued beyond traditional digital marketing and teamed up with famous brands and media like Heinz ketchup and *The Real Housewives of Orange County*. One particularly creative collaboration was with National Geographic, which aired an episode of its *Underdogs* nature documentary series, narrated by Reynolds, featuring a real-life Wolverine; how clever of them. This level of cross-platform synergy demonstrates how the Deadpool franchise has embraced modern multimedia marketing strategies that are fan-driven and participatory at their core (*Beyond traditional ads*, 2024; Chilton, 2024a; McClintock, 2024). As noted by Guo (2022), "modern fandom has shifted from simple consumption to participatory engagement, with fans creating their own paratexts, from memes to reaction videos (Bi, 2019; Geraets, 2024; Guo, 2022, p. 225); this shift from a top-down approach to a bottom-up model is central to the film's success" (p. 225). Lemke (2006) emphasizes the importance of cross-media connections, stating that "the principle of hypertext or hypermedia...applies to the social and cultural linkages among our reading of books, viewing of films and television...[and] surfing the Web" (p. 4). In this context, *Deadpool & Wolverine* relied on cinematic storytelling and the intricate web of fan interactions across multiple platforms.

Additionally, the film's cameos and acknowledgements of past Marvel films and comics hit the mark for fans, making it even more enjoyable. *Deadpool & Wolverine* brought back familiar elements from previous films while introducing fresh stories. It also included some digs at the actors themselves. Like the ever-popular American Girl Company, Marvel "uses nostalgia as a tool to foster consumer devotion to the brand, constructing a powerful narrative of revisionist history to sell idealized pasts and childhoods" (Rosner, 2014, p. 36) and enact a "sense of completeness" (Rosner, 2014, p. 47) and rightness for many of the cameo characters.

Deadpool & Wolverine is a film packed with Easter eggs, which references both Marvel's extended universe and contemporary pop culture. It turned into a pop-culture scrapbook chock full of nods to Marvel canon.

Deadpool's fourth-wall-breaking antics and Wolverine's surly reluctance to participate in Deadpool's chaos create a synergistic relationship between characters that fans love, with Wolverine telling Wade: "You really are God's perfect idiot" as Deadpool 'accidentally' gets his variant, Nicepool killed when, unaware that Nicepool's body does not regenerate, uses Nicepool as a shield when the other "void" Deadpool variants of the Deadpool Corps attack Wolverine, Wade, Dogpool and Nicepool as they attempt to stop Paradox from destroying Wade's world and those he loves. The film's meta-humour drew audiences in. As Bausela Buccianti (2023) points out, Deadpool knows he is in a story and talks to the fans through that self-awareness. The clever interplay between his awareness and the audience's involvement is crucial to the film's continued success in theatres and eventually on the Disney Plus app. Lemke (2006) notes that "as our culture increasingly enmeshes us in constellations of textual, visual, and other themes...these cross-activity and cross-medium connections tend to become coherently structured" (p. 7). In *Deadpool & Wolverine*, the marketing strategy utilized traditional advertisements like billboards, interviews, previews, and technology to entice fans. Viewers could easily access trailers, behind-the-scenes clips, and interactive content across many electronic platforms (*Beyond traditional ads*, 2024; Chilton, 2024a; McClintock, 2024). This focus on social media highlights how audiences now consume and interact with media differently and how Marvel turned its audience into a vital marketing tool (*Beyond traditional ads*, 2024; Chilton, 2024a; McClintock, 2024).

Despite its successes, *Deadpool & Wolverine* faced critiques highlighting the tension between fan service and narrative depth (Chilton, 2024b; Hertz, 2024). Critics noted that while the film was filled with jokes and references that delighted fans, it lacked purpose (Hertz, 2024). As Chilton (2024) states in his July 30, 2024 article, "the film is about absolutely nothing, a film

with no discernible purpose or artistic ambitions, beyond the perpetuation of its own corporate myth." This critique raises exciting questions about how practical a fandom-driven approach can be when focusing more on Easter eggs than storytelling. By leaning heavily on nostalgia and inside jokes, the film loses viewers looking for deeper and more meaningful content. Although, if someone is going to a *Deadpool* film, they already know what they are in for. However, this is not just a film for fans; there are jokes for every viewer, so nobody feels left out and disconnected from the story. However, Marvel and Reynolds are pretty good at exploiting fan enthusiasm for financial gain. The risk of prioritizing profitability over genuine storytelling is high as studios increasingly focus on maximizing audience reach during recession times.

Callbacks are seen throughout the film, referencing actors playing characters they had been fan-cast in, such as Henry Cavill as the Wolverine, who appeared as said character in a tiny scene with Deadpool saying to him: "You know, from behind, you look a little bit like Henry...The Cavill-rine. The legends are true." There are also unexpected fourth-wall breaks, such as jokes where Deadpool asks for better film set employees. A great example is Deadpool saying to Channing Tatum, as the mutant Gambit, a character with a strong Cajun accent: "I'm sorry, beautiful, how could this be gentle? Who is your dialect coach? The minions? I feel like we're missing important exposition here," with audiences thinking similar thoughts as Tatum's coached Cajun accent is so thick, you can barely understand what his character is saying in most of his scenes. That being said, however 'bad' Tatum's accent comes off, fans that have deep-dived into his interest in this role know that Gambit is Tatum's favourite Marvel character and that Tatum was supposed to play him in *X-Men Origins: Wolverine* before the role went to Taylor Kitsch due to scheduling conflicts on Tatum's end (Buchannon, 2024).

For long-time comic fans, watching Deadpool and Wolverine battle side-by-side—and occasionally against each other—is the realization of years of speculative conversations and fan fiction. The meta-narrative of the *Deadpool* franchise technique is taken to new heights in *Deadpool & Wolverine*. In a particularly memorable scene at the film's beginning, Deadpool

says: "There are 206 bones in the human body, 207 if I'm watching *Gossip Girl*." For those who know of Ryan Reynolds' personal life, he is married to former *Gossip Girl* actress Blakey Lively. Fans were also delighted to learn that Lively plays Ladypool, a *Deadpool* variant who leads *Deadpool Corps*. Lively also influenced many of the film's references and musical choices (Massabrook, 2024), so it is also a love letter to Lively from Reynolds. Moments like these showcase how deeply intertwined reality is with fiction in the film.

Deadpool & Wolverine can be seen as more than just a movie—it functions as a public archive of fan culture, pop culture references, and Marvel's broader cinematic history. The *Deadpool* franchise thrives off its own campiness and smart cinema setup (Tsykrun, 2022, p. 88). With its usage of Easter eggs referencing obscure Marvel comics to jokes about mainstream trends, each scene in *Deadpool & Wolverine* is another fragment in Marvel's scrapbook. The idea of a film as a 'public archive' also shows how well it incorporates multimedia literacy into its structure. As multimedia literacy expands beyond traditional forms of reading and writing to include digital fluency and social engagement, film fans engage with it through its narrative and the algorithms on their social media for-you pages. The way that fans pushed for a *Wolverine* and *Deadpool* film is similar to what happened with the *Sonic the Hedgehog* live-action movie in 2020, where fans were unhappy with *Sonic's* animation design and pushed for a redesign (Lee, 2020). Their voices were heard, showing how much influence audiences have on Hollywood blockbusters.

Deadpool & Wolverine showcases fans' power in the media forms they love, especially in today's films and television series. Although the film might not become a timeless classic, it significantly shifts the dynamic between creators and audiences. As audiences continue to play an essential role in the production and reception of media, the line between creator and audience is only becoming more blurred—minus a paycheck and job title. This film is a shining example of this shift. It demonstrates how fan engagement and participatory culture change how films are made, potentially forever (Chilton, 2024b). Hollywood blockbusters are becoming

collaborative, interactive experiences resembling user-generated content. As pop culture continues to evolve, *Deadpool & Wolverine* will stand as a testament to how fandom can reverse the influence. By embracing trends, Marvel has secured its place at the forefront of modern cinema and cemented its relationship with the most essential player in the game: the fan, because "sometimes the people we save, they save us right back" (*Deadpool & Wolverine*, 2024).

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